movement prayer

Lectio Divina

Overview

Lectio Divina, which literally means "divine reading," is a prayerful way to hear God's voice while reading Scripture. This wonderful step-by-step way of approaching the Bible dates back to the third century and has been used in many monastic traditions throughout the centuries.

The following instructions show how Lectio Divina can be used with the Discovery Bible Study questions to provide a greater emphasis in hearing from God either for a group of Jesus followers or for individuals.

Getting Started

Begin by following the first steps of the Discovery Bible Study with the Community Questions and Review of the Accountability Questions from the previous week.

READY - Invite everyone to come into God's presence through prayer, to slow down, relax, and intentionally release the chaos and noise in their minds to God.

READ - Invite someone to slowly read the passage out loud, pausing briefly between each verse. Instruct the group to take a few minutes to silently reflect on the passage that has just been read. (Individuals doing this can reflect on each word while they write the passage word-for-word as it appears in the Bible.) Ask God to reveal whatever He wants you to see in this passage.

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REFLECT - In an attitude of prayer, select a second person to re-read the passage slowly, while taking note of whatever word or phrase stands out and whatever feelings, memories, or thoughts surface. Talk to God as you explore your feelings and thoughts. Ask individuals to share what words or phrases stood out to them that God might be drawing them to consider. Dwell on whatever part of the passage catches your attention.

You can narrow your focus if most of the people in your group are drawn to the same part of the passage. Share with one another why you think God directed you to this passage and any related thoughts, memories, or emotions. Individuals can note their feelings and thoughts to share later with others.

RESPOND - Ask God how He is inviting you to respond to the passage. Ask the group to press into God and wait until He reveals a specific, practical action step He is calling them to take. Write down your responses.

Give the group time to reflect on who they can tell about their spiritual experience. See if God will bring someone to mind. Direct the group to ask God to show them with whom and how they can share their spiritual experience in an appropriate way that would bless other people.

Encourage group members to tell the group how they plan to respond and who they plan to share this experience with. Encourage those who do this individually to share what God has revealed to them with another believer.

Pray for each other to have the courage to take action on what God has called each one of them to obey and to share this with someone else.

REST - Finish your meeting by lingering in the presence of God. Allow the words you received from God to sink in deeply. Thank God for the time you have enjoyed in His presence and for speaking to you. Ask God to help you follow through with what He has shown you and then lift one another up in prayer.

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Other Options

Lectio Divina can take a little longer than a normal group meeting. You can divide the steps over two weeks. One week you look at the new passage and the next week you spend in review and group prayer. Individuals can read the passage and reflect on it over multiple days.

Group members can go through these steps individually throughout the week. When the group meets, each member can then share how God spoke to them.

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